

guest column

Jagbir Singh

BEYOND OLYMPIC HOCKEY

Indian hockey is not dead yet. We can replicate Spain's dramatic upsurge in just four years.



After I saw India concede a second-minute goal to Austria in the Olympic hockey qualifiers, I knew my remaining nights were going to be sleepless—and not only because of the time difference. The message that was sent out by that match was clear. There is a lack of understanding of the pace and pressure of international hockey among players and

coaches. Our play is so predictable that any opposing coach or player would find it easy to read. The bad news is that from here it will become difficult for India to stay among hockey's elite if we don't change now.

All of us know that India's grip on hockey began to slip in 1968, when we failed to win an Olympic gold for the first time. Only in the 1970s did we realise that gold was not preordained for India and its price was only getting higher. There were few bright spots like winning the 1975 World Cup but the advent of astro turf led to an increase in the number of nations playing hockey. European countries played each other often with only one target: countering the Asian style of hockey.

India has also been harmed by false projections and promises by officials highlighting small achievements before major tournaments to keep hopes alive and justify their positions. But the big event always brings out the bald truth: we may be there or thereabout among the top countries in hockey but we are still struggling to find the right path to the top or how to remain there.

Ironically, we don't know the real numbers playing in India—it could be the highest in the world—because of the ancient working style in our state associations. No one seems to see the need for modernisation, computerisation of data, records or registration of players. So while we do know that Korea is a country of 5,000 hockey players and has one Olympic medal to its name, we don't know how

many play the sport that brought us eight Olympic golds.

Our old hockey culture also needs to be overhauled. Our coaching and training needs to embrace modern skills and tactical awareness. We need to understand how much hockey has changed from the sideline push to the slap shot, from the forehand hit to the backhand shot. Who better than Ric Charlesworth, who is a living legend, expressly brought to help India. India now needs to understand his vision by giving him a tenure till the 2012 Olympics.

I believe there is too much dogmatism and rigid thinking in Indian hockey. Star players are kept at bay because we convert their confidence into "attitude", and make it a pretext to replace them with youngsters. The new players receive a negative signal from day one and are injected with a feeling of inferiority. So we can never field a team which looks into the



NADIR: Indian players after their defeat against England

eyes of opponents and challenges them even before entering the field. When the play goes man to man, there is a lot of chatter, you'll hear rival forwards saying, "stay away from me" or a defender warning, "don't go left, I'm too strong there". The Indians do it too but not as emphatically as others. Before the Chile qualifier, the British coach got his visiting cards printed in Chinese. Now, that's confidence.

The television and papers have been full of headlines that the national game has been put

to shame. It has been put to shame for the last three decades through a slow poison of poor governance, unrealistic approach and lack of professionalism. In times of other crises, India has always stood together, but I wonder why we did nothing about the deep crisis in a sport synonymous with our Olympic pride. When I hear people saying hockey is dead, my blood boils. In 2002, Spain finished 11th at the World Cup, two years later it won the Champions Trophy and in 2006 was a World Cup medallist. Why not India?

Olympian and Arjuna awardee Jagbir Singh played on the Indian forward line from 1985-1995.